9.1 Applications in Medicine

9.1.1 Recombinant Human Insulin

The Human insulin is synthesized by the β cells of Islets of Langerhans in the pancreas. It is formed of 51 aminoacids which are arranged in two polypeptide chains, A and B. The polypeptide chain A has 21 amino acids while the polypeptide chain B has 30 amino acids. Both A and B chains are attached together by disulphide bonds. Insulin controls the levels of glucose in blood. It facilitates the cellular uptake and utilization of glucose for the release of energy. Deficiency of insulin leads to diabetes mellitus which is characterized by increased blood glucose concentration and a complex of symptoms which may lead to death, if untreated. A continuous program of insulin dependence is required to treat this deficiency.

In the early years, insulin isolated and purified from the pancreas of pigs and cows was used to treat diabetic patients. Due to minor differences in the structure of the animal insulin as compared to human insulin, it resulted in the occurrence of allergic reactions in some diabetic patients. Production of insulin by recombinant DNA technology started in the late 1970s. This technique involved the insertion of human insulin gene on the plasmids of *E.coli*. The polypeptide chains are synthesized as a precursor called pre-pro insulin, which contains A and B segments linked by a third chain (C) and preceded by a leader sequence. The leader sequence is removed after translation and the C chain is excised, leaving the A and B polypeptide chains **(Fig. 9.1)**.

Insulin was the first ever pharmaceutical product of recombinant DNA technology administered to humans. The approval to use recombinant insulin for diabetes mellitus was given in 1982. In 1986 human insulin was marketed under the trade name Humulin.

Best and Banting in 1921, isolated insulin from the pancreatic islets of a dog and demonstrated its effectiveness against diabetes.

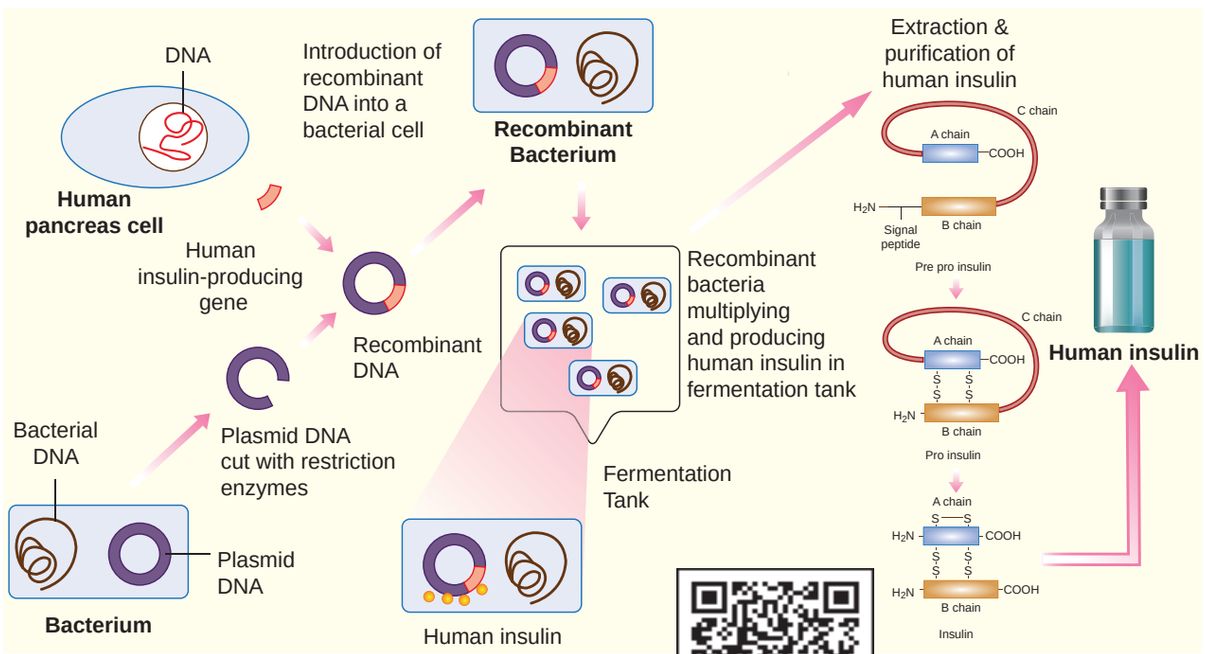


Fig. 9.1 Human Insulin Production

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